

After Christendom

How to Follow Jesus in Post-Christian America

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

— Jeremiah 29:7

Introduction: After the Water Receded

For most of American history a Christian and a citizen were swimming in the same water, and almost nobody noticed the water was there.

You could assume things. You could assume your neighbor shared your basic moral vocabulary even if he never darkened a church door, because the vocabulary was in the air he breathed too. You could assume the stores would be closed on Sunday morning, that the President would end his speeches asking God to bless the country and mean roughly the God you meant, that a pastor was a respected man in town and not a suspicious one. None of it required anyone to actually believe very much. That was the point. It was the water. To be a decent American and to be a vaguely Christian person were close enough to the same thing that you could go your whole life without telling them apart.

That world is gone, and the striking thing is how fast it went. In the span of a single generation the share of Americans who claim no religion at all went from a rounding error to something near a third of the country. Belief did not just decline. It changed categories. The philosopher Charles Taylor spent eight hundred pages making this one point, that we have moved from an age in which faith was the assumed default to an age in which it is one option among many, and a contested one, held by people who know their neighbors have looked at the same evidence and chosen otherwise. That is a different kind of believing. It is belief

without the water.

And here is the thing the American church has mostly refused to accept. The water is not coming back.

We are, a great many of us, flopping on the sand. Furious, grieving, certain that the faith itself is in its death throes, casting around for someone to blame, the schools or the courts or the other party or the young. I understand the grief, and I am not going to mock it, because something real did die. But I want to say as plainly as I know how what actually died, because almost everything depends on getting this right. What is dying is not Christianity. What is dying is Christendom. They are not the same thing, and the church's failure to tell them apart is the single most expensive mistake we are making right now.

Christendom is the arrangement. It is the long stretch of history, running roughly from a Roman emperor's conversion to a few decades ago in America, in which Christianity was assumed, established, respectable, and backed by the power of the culture. Christianity is the thing itself. A crucified and risen Lord, a gospel, a people, a way of life that was already centuries old before any emperor ever heard of it. For a long time we got to have both at once, and we forgot they could be separated, and so when the arrangement started to fall we assumed the faith was falling with it. It is not. The scaffolding is coming down. The building is fine. We have just been told for so long that the scaffolding was the building that we can no longer tell the difference, and we are weeping at the wrong funeral.

I can say this with a certain freedom, because I never swam in the water. I did not grow up Christian. I came to Christ out of atheism, as a grown man, in the full daylight of the secular age, as exactly the kind of skeptical outsider this book is partly written to reach. I have never once needed the culture to assume

the faith on my behalf, because the culture I lived in assumed the opposite, and Jesus turned out to be enough anyway. That is not a small thing to say to a church in a panic. The faith does not need the scaffolding. It never did. If anything the scaffolding needed the faith, and borrowed its prestige, and gave very little back.

Lesslie Newbigin saw this before most of us. He spent the better part of forty years as a missionary in India, and when he finally came home to Britain he found a country that had become, by his own account, a far harder mission field than the one he had left, and a church that did not even know it had become one. He had crossed the world to bring the gospel to people who had never heard it, and come back to people who had heard it and moved on, which is a different and lonelier kind of soil to work. The West, he understood, is no longer pre-Christian. It is post-Christian. It has the church in its memory the way a man has a marriage he walked out of, and that is not nothing, and it is not the same as never having married at all.

This book is about that country, and how to follow Jesus inside it without losing your nerve or your soul. I am going to argue something that will sound at first like bad news and turn out to be the opposite. The church has lived after Christendom before. It lived before Christendom for three hundred years, as a small and frequently hated minority with no power to speak of, and it was never more alive, never more clear about what it was, never more dangerous to the empire that despised it. We are not being marched toward extinction. We are being marched back to the beginning, which is the one place the church has always known how to thrive.

I am not going to tell you how to take the country back. That is one of the two bad answers, and I will spend a chapter on why. I

am not going to tell you how to make peace with the age by quietly handing it everything it asks for, which is the other one. I am going to try to do something harder and older. I am going to try to help us be the church again. Deep, strange, unafraid, and free. The way we were before we had anything to lose.

Chapter One: The Water We Forgot Was There

There is a small story the writer David Foster Wallace told a room of graduates, and it has outlived him because it is true about more than he meant. Two young fish are swimming along and an older fish passes them going the other way and says, morning, boys, how is the water. The two young fish swim on a while, and finally one of them looks at the other and says, what is water.

That is Christendom. It was the water, and the whole problem with water is that the fish cannot see it. American Christians have spent so long inside the assumption that the culture was basically on their side that they stopped experiencing it as an assumption at all. It just felt like reality. It felt like the way things are. And a thing you cannot see is a thing you cannot examine, which means you also cannot tell where it ends and your actual faith begins.

So let me try to make the water visible, because you cannot follow Jesus after Christendom until you can see the Christendom you are after. It began, as a historical matter, with a Roman emperor. For its first three centuries the church had no political standing of any kind. Then Constantine won a battle in 312, issued an edict of toleration the next year, called the bishops to Nicaea in 325, and within a lifetime, under Theodosius in 380, the faith that Rome had fed to lions became the official religion of Rome. That is the hinge. That is the day the church stopped being a persecuted minority and started being the establishment,

and it stayed the establishment, in one form or another, for sixteen hundred years.

America was supposed to be the exception, and in the narrow legal sense it was. There was no state church, no bishop on the public payroll, no establishment of religion, and thank God for that. But what we built instead was sneakier and in some ways stronger. We built a cultural establishment without a legal one. The faith was woven into the civic furniture so thoroughly that you did not need a law to enforce it. The schools opened in prayer. The politicians quoted the King James whether they had read it or not. The calendar bent around the Christian year. A man could be entirely faithless and still be carried along by a current that ran, unmistakably, in a Christian direction. That current was the water.

And here is what the water did to us, the thing we are only now able to see. It taught us, without ever saying so, that being a Christian meant being central. Normal. Respectable. The home team. It formed in us a set of expectations we mistook for the faith itself, the expectation that the culture would back us, that the institutions would defer to us, that to be a believer was to be a member of the majority that set the terms. None of that is in the New Testament. All of it felt, to us, like Christianity. We took the privileges of the arrangement and quietly folded them into the gospel, until losing the privileges felt exactly like losing the gospel.

We mistook the water for the faith, and so when the water drained we were sure we were watching the faith die. We were watching the water drain.

Charles Taylor calls the new condition a secular age, and he is careful to say he does not mean a world emptied of belief. He

means a world in which belief has become contestable, in which the faith that was once the unspoken floor under everyone's feet is now one position a person takes, knowing full well that the thoughtful people across the table have taken another. That shift is the end of the water. It is not the end of God. It is the end of God being assumed. And a church that only knew how to believe in the shallows of assumption is going to have to learn, quickly and at cost, how to believe in the open sea.

I find I am not afraid of this, and I have had to ask myself why, and the answer is in the introduction. I met Christ in the open sea. I never had the water. So when I watch the culture withdraw its old deference I do not feel the ground give way, because that ground was never under my faith to begin with. I want that for the frightened church. Not the fear. The freedom on the other side of it, which is the freedom of a faith that has finally found out it was standing on the Rock the whole time and not on the water at all.

Chapter Two: The Day the Scaffolding Came Down

Ask people when it happened and they will name a different year depending on what they lost. Someone will say 1962, when the Supreme Court took organized prayer out of the public schools and a certain kind of Christian felt the first cold draft of being told no. Someone else will point further back, or further forward, to a court case or an election or the morning they realized the children had simply stopped going. The truth is it was not a day. It was a slow leak that became, somewhere around the turn of this century, a flood.

You can watch it in the numbers, and the numbers are not subtle. In the early 1970s about one American in twenty told a survey-taker he had no religion at all. By the 2020s it was getting close to one in three. The fastest growing religious group in the country became the people who check the box that says none. That is not a dip. That is a category of person who barely existed in your grandfather's America becoming one of the largest religious blocs in your children's. Whatever was holding the old arrangement up, it stopped holding around the year 2000, and the fall has been steep ever since.

But a number like that hides the more important change, which is not how many people left but what replaced the thing they left. The sociologist Robert Bellah saw it coming back in 1985, in a book called *Habits of the Heart*, where he interviewed a woman he called Sheila who described her faith in a sentence that should be carved over the door of this whole era. She said, I believe in

God, I am not a religious fanatic, I cannot remember the last time I went to church, my faith has carried me a long way, it is Sheilaism, just my own little voice. She had named her religion after herself. Bellah understood that she was not a rebel. She was the future. The self had quietly become the highest authority, the final court of appeal, and the church was demoted from the place where you go to find the truth to one more resource you might consult on your way to deciding it for yourself.

That is the world the scaffolding came down into. Not a hostile world, mostly, not at first. A world that had simply relocated the throne. The therapeutic replaced the confessional. The question stopped being is it true and became does it work for me, and a faith that makes demands does not survive that question for long, because the whole point of a demand is that it does not bend to whether it works for you.

Now here is where I want to be careful, because this is exactly the place the American church loses its head. We look at all of this, the empty box and the little voice and the relocated throne, and we conclude that the faith is dying. And I am telling you that the faith is not dying. The scaffolding is coming down. What we are watching is the collapse of cultural Christianity, the broad shallow belief that the water held up for free, the kind of faith that cost nothing because the culture subsidized it. That faith is evaporating, yes. It was always going to. It had no roots of its own.

The cultural Christian was never converted. He was carried. And you cannot mourn the loss of a faith that was only ever the buoyancy of the water.

So we are grieving the wrong death. We are standing over the body of cultural Christianity, weeping as though it were the

church, and it was never the church. It was the church's shadow on the wall of a culture that has now turned out the light. The real church, the one with roots, the one that costs something, is still standing in the room. It is smaller than the shadow made it look. It is also, for the first time in a long time, unmistakably itself. And a church that has stopped being able to count on the culture is a church that is about to find out what it actually believes, which is the most clarifying thing that can happen to a people, and the most frightening, and the most necessary.

Chapter Three: Take It Back or Give It Up

Tell a man the water has drained and he will almost always reach for one of two buckets. He will try to pour the water back, or he will decide he never needed it and learn to breathe whatever is left. The American church has split, more or less, along exactly that line, and the tragedy is that both halves are sure the other half is the problem, and both halves are making the same mistake.

The first answer is to take it back. If Christendom is falling, then the task of the faithful is to hold it up, by force if necessary, to seize the levers of the culture and the state and crank the old arrangement back into place. This is the impulse behind the harder forms of Christian nationalism, the fusion of cross and flag, the conviction that the way to save the faith is to make the nation Christian again by making it obey. I have written a whole book against the gentler version of this, the slow substitution of God bless America for thy kingdom come, so I will not repeat all of it here. I will only name the thing at the root. The take-it-back answer believes that the kingdom of God can be advanced by the sword of Caesar, and the moment it believes that, it has stopped being able to tell the two cities apart. It mistakes the nation for the kingdom, baptizes a tribe, and produces a Christianity that is finally indistinguishable from a voting bloc with a worship band. You can win every election with that and lose the only thing the church was ever sent to keep.

The second answer is to give it up. If the culture has moved on, then the task of the faithful is to catch up, to quietly file down

every edge of the faith that the age finds offensive, to keep the architecture and the music and the warm feeling and let the substance go. This is the impulse behind the slow accommodation of the progressive church, the steady trade of the hard sayings of Jesus for the settled opinions of the educated class. It always presents itself as compassion, and sometimes it sincerely is. But name the thing at the root here too. The give-it-up answer believes that the church survives by agreeing with the world, and a church that agrees with the world about everything has nothing left to say to it and no reason to exist. It will be applauded all the way to its own empty buildings, because the world does not need a slightly more spiritual version of what it already believes.

One side wants to conquer Babylon. The other wants to move in and change its name to home. Neither one is willing to do the harder thing, which is to live in Babylon as someone who belongs to a different city.

Look at what the two answers have in common, because it is the most important thing in this chapter. Both of them are driven by the same fear. Both of them, underneath the bluster and underneath the compassion, do not actually believe the faith can survive without the culture's backing. The nationalist cannot imagine a faithful church that is not also a powerful one, so he reaches for power. The accommodationist cannot imagine a faithful church that the culture despises, so he reaches for approval. Different reaches, same terror. Both of them have looked at the receding water and concluded that the church cannot live without it. Both of them are wrong, and the first three centuries of the church are the proof, and we will spend the next four chapters there.

I have felt the pull of both, and I will not pretend otherwise. There is a version of me that wants the old deference back, that misses being able to assume the room. And there is a version of me that wants the clever room's approval, that would love to be the kind of Christian the people who matter find reasonable. Both of those wants are the flesh, not the Spirit. Both of them are the cultural Christian in me, grieving his lost water. The man who met Christ in the open sea knows better. He knows the church was born with no power and no approval and it converted an empire anyway, and it did not do it by taking Rome or by becoming Rome. It did it by being something Rome had never seen.

Chapter Four: Babylon Is Not the Enemy

Six hundred years before Christ the unthinkable happened to the people of God. Babylon came, and the walls of Jerusalem came down, and the temple, the actual dwelling place of God on earth, was burned to the ground, and the people were marched a thousand miles into the heart of a pagan empire to live among people who worshipped other gods and spoke another tongue and had every reason to despise them. If you want to know how to live after your world ends, you go to the people whose world actually ended, and you watch what God told them to do.

What He told them is one of the most shocking things in all of Scripture, and we have read it so often at weddings and on coffee mugs that we have sanded the shock right off it. Through the prophet Jeremiah, God sent a letter to the exiles in Babylon, and the letter did not say what either faction wanted it to say. There was a faction that wanted to fight, that listened to prophets like Hananiah promising that the yoke of Babylon would be snapped within two years and the whole nightmare reversed. And there was a faction that wanted to disappear, to stop being Jewish, to melt into Babylon and make the ache of being different go away. God said no to both.

Here is what He said instead. Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat what they produce. Take wives, have sons and daughters, multiply there and do not decrease. And then the line that should stop your heart. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its

behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Seek the shalom of Babylon. Pray for the prosperity of the empire that burned your temple. Not conquer it. Not flee it. Bless it, while belonging entirely to Someone else.

Sit in how strange that is. God does not tell them to take Babylon back, to organize, to agitate, to restore the old arrangement by force. And He does not tell them to give themselves up, to assimilate, to quietly become Babylonians with a few private memories of Zion. He tells them to do the third thing, the thing neither faction had imagined, which is to settle in as a distinct people and pour themselves out for the good of a city that is not their home and never will be. Plant gardens. Gardens are slow. A garden is a bet on staying. A garden is what you plant when you have stopped expecting rescue by Tuesday and started expecting to be faithful for a lifetime in a place you did not choose.

God did not tell the exiles to defeat Babylon or to become Babylon. He told them to seek its good and keep their souls. That is the whole vocation of the church after Christendom, in a single sentence, written six centuries before the church existed.

There were false prophets in Babylon, and it is worth saying what made them false, because they are still with us. The false prophet was the one who told the people the exile would be short. Two years, Hananiah said, and we will all go home and the furniture will be just as we left it. He was lying, and Jeremiah told him so, and Jeremiah told the people the number that the take-it-back crowd never wants to hear. Seventy years. A lifetime. You will die here, most of you. Your grandchildren will go home, not you. So stop waiting for the water to come back and start planting gardens in the world as it actually is. The false

prophet promises you your old country by the weekend. The true prophet hands you a shovel.

This is why I say Babylon is not the enemy, and I mean it as more than a turn of phrase. The post-Christian culture around us is not the empire we are called to defeat or the empire we are called to join. It is the city we are called to seek the good of, on behalf of a God it does not know, as a people who refuse both the sword and the surrender. Some have called this faithful presence, and the phrase is a good one. Present, fully, in the life of the place. Faithful, completely, to the God of the place we actually belong to. The exiles learned to be both, and the ones who learned it gave us Daniel, and Esther, and a witness so bright that pagan kings ended up praising the God of Israel. That did not happen because the exiles took Babylon. It happened because they sought its welfare and would not bow.

Chapter Five: The Church Before the Empire

Here is the fact that should reorganize how the frightened church thinks about its future, and almost no one says it out loud. The most explosive growth in the entire history of Christianity happened when the church had no political power whatsoever. Not a little power. None. It was illegal, it was slandered, it was periodically hunted, its members met in homes and catacombs and were burned and fed to animals for sport, and across three centuries of that it went from a few thousand frightened followers of a crucified Galilean to somewhere near half the Roman Empire. It conquered Rome before Constantine ever lifted a finger, and it did it from underneath.

The sociologist Rodney Stark sat down and ran the arithmetic on this, and the arithmetic is astonishing. To get from a handful of believers in the year 40 to the tens of millions that the church plainly numbered by the early 300s, you do not need miracles of mass conversion. You need a steady growth rate of around forty percent a decade, the same kind of rate sociologists see in vigorous new religious movements, sustained for almost three hundred years. The question Stark spent his career on is the only question that matters. Why. Why did this odd, powerless, persecuted minority keep growing through the worst the empire could throw at it, when by every worldly measure it should have been stamped out a dozen times over.

The answer is not what we want it to be. It was not strategy and it was not platform and it was not cultural power, because they

had none of those things. It was that they lived in a way the empire could not explain. When the great plagues came, the Antonine plague in the 160s and the plague that bears Cyprian's name in the 250s, and the cities filled with the dying, the pagan response was rational and ancient. You fled. You left the sick by the road, even your own, and you got out, because to stay was to die. And the Christians stayed. They nursed the sick, their own and their pagan neighbors, at appalling cost to themselves, because they served a Lord who had touched lepers and because they did not believe death was the end of the story. A nursed body sometimes lives. A pagan nursed back from the edge by a Christian who had no earthly reason to do it does not forget who sat by his bed.

It went further than the plagues. In a world that exposed unwanted infants on the hillside to die, mostly the girls, the Christians went out and gathered them up and raised them as their own. In a world that treated women as property, the church gave them honor, and widows a place, and marriage a dignity it had not had. In a world sorted ruthlessly by class and blood, the church sat slave and master at one table and called them brothers, and meant it. The Letter to Diognetus, written by some anonymous Christian in the second century to a puzzled pagan, put it exactly. Christians, he wrote, live in their own countries, but only as sojourners. Every foreign land is their homeland, and every homeland a foreign land. They are in the flesh, but they do not live according to the flesh. They are the soul of the world.

They had no power, so they had only their lives. And their lives turned out to be the most persuasive argument the ancient world had ever encountered.

Tertullian, writing around the year 200 while the persecutions

were still on, threw a line at the empire that has never lost its edge. The blood of the martyrs, he said, is seed. He meant it as a taunt and a fact. Every time you kill us, more of us appear, because the watching world cannot stop asking what a man could possibly have that would let him die like that without hatred and without fear. The powerlessness was not a handicap the early church overcame. It was the soil. A church that could not coerce had to convert, and a church that could not buy loyalty had to earn it, and a church that could not call down the magistrate had to call down nothing but the witness of its own astonishing life. It is precisely the church I am describing, the church before the empire, that we are being handed back. We have been so afraid of losing our power that we forgot our power was the very thing that, the first time around, we did not have.

Chapter Six: Augustine Watches Rome Fall

In the year 410 the impossible happened. Alaric and the Goths came over the walls and sacked the city of Rome, and the civilized world went into shock the way you go into shock when a parent dies, even an old and failing parent, because some part of you had quietly believed they would always be there. Rome was the eternal city. Rome was eleven hundred years old. Rome had been, for a lifetime now, a Christian empire, ever since Theodosius made the faith official in 380. And it fell, to barbarians, in three days of fire. The grief was total, and out of the grief came two accusations, and the church is still answering both of them.

The pagans said, this is your fault. Rome was strong when Rome honored the old gods, and you Christians talked her out of them, and now the gods have withdrawn their protection and the barbarians are in the forum, and it is on your heads. And many Christians, which is the part we forget, were privately devastated for the opposite reason. They had come to believe that a Christian empire was the point, that God had crowned history with a baptized Rome, that the kingdom and the empire had fused into one glorious permanent thing. And now the permanent thing was burning, and their faith was buckling, because if Christian Rome could fall then what exactly had God promised, and what exactly were they standing on.

Into that double grief, an aging bishop in North Africa sat down and wrote the book that should be the constitution of every

Christian living after Christendom. Augustine spent thirteen years on *The City of God*, twenty-two books, and the argument at the heart of it is one idea that cuts the panic off at the knees. There are, he said, two cities, and they have been intertwined since the beginning, and they are built by two loves. The earthly city is built by love of self extending to contempt of God. The heavenly city is built by love of God extending to contempt of self. Rome was the earthly city. Rome was always the earthly city. Rome was never the City of God, not for one day, not even when it flew the cross over the legions, and so the fall of Rome is not the fall of the kingdom, because the two were never the same thing in the first place.

Do you see what he is doing, and do you see that it is exactly our problem. The Christians of 410 had made precisely the mistake we have made. They had fused the faith with its political establishment so completely that when the establishment fell they thought God had failed. Augustine pried the two apart with both hands. He told them that the City of God is not made of marble and does not depend on legions and cannot be sacked by any Alaric, because it is the company of all who love God across every nation and every age, and it is moving through history toward a country that no barbarian can burn. The empire was the scaffolding. The City of God was the building. And the bishop made them look at the difference while the ash was still falling.

Rome was never the City of God. So the fall of Rome is not the fall of God. Learn that lesson now, while it is only your country shaking, and you will not lose your faith when it finally gives way.

There is a detail at the end of Augustine's life that I cannot get out of my head, and I will leave it with you because it carries the

whole weight of this book. As Augustine lay dying in the year 430, the Vandals were at the gates of his own city, Hippo, besieging it. The world he had defended was visibly coming apart around his deathbed. The barbarians were not a theory. They were outside the wall. And he died in peace, this man, with the enemy in sight of his window, because he had spent thirteen years teaching himself and everyone who would listen that his city, his real city, was not the one under siege. That is the freedom on offer to us. Not the freedom of a church that wins. The freedom of a church that has stopped confusing the burning empire with the indestructible kingdom, and can therefore watch the smoke without despair, and get back to the work of loving the God whose city has no walls to breach.

Chapter Seven: Elect Exiles

We keep treating exile as the church's emergency, the disaster that befalls us when things go wrong, the punishment for some failure of nerve or numbers. I want to argue the opposite, and I want to argue it from the Scriptures, because it changes everything about how you carry the days we are living in. Exile is not the church's emergency. Exile is the church's native condition. It is the normal key the song is written in. Christendom was the exception, a sixteen-hundred-year holiday from our actual address, and the holiday is over, and we are simply going home to the strange country we always lived in.

Start with Daniel, because Daniel is the master class. A young man torn out of Jerusalem and dropped into the court of the very empire that destroyed his home, given a pagan name and a pagan education and a seat in the administration of Babylon. And watch what he does, because it is neither of the two bad answers. He does not lead a resistance and he does not melt away. He serves the empire, brilliantly, with such excellence that pagan king after pagan king promotes him and trusts him. And he will not bow. When the law commands the worship of the king's image he keeps praying toward Jerusalem with the windows open, not hidden, not in revolt, just faithful in plain sight, and he takes the lions' den as the price. Daniel is the exile who seeks the welfare of the city and will not bend the knee, both at once, for a lifetime, and dies old and honored in a foreign land with his soul entirely intact.

Then come to the New Testament and find that the apostles simply assume this is what we are. Peter opens his first letter by

addressing the Christians scattered across Asia Minor as elect exiles of the dispersion. Elect exiles. Chosen, and strangers, in the same breath. A few lines later he calls them sojourners and exiles and tells them to live such honorable lives among the pagans that the very people slandering them will end up glorifying God when they see the good works with their own eyes. That is the Diognetus strategy straight from an apostle's pen. You are not citizens of this order who happen to believe some religious things. You are resident aliens of a coming kingdom who happen to hold a passport here, and you are to be the best and most generous neighbors this city has ever had, precisely because your hope is fixed somewhere it cannot reach.

The book of Hebrews says it with a kind of ache. These all died in faith, it says of the patriarchs, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth. And then, here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come. There it is again, Augustine's two cities, sitting in the New Testament centuries before Augustine, the settled conviction of the whole people of God that we are travelers here, that our papers are provisional, that the country we are heading for is the only one with foundations whose designer and builder is God.

Christendom taught us to feel at home, and feeling at home is the one thing the New Testament never promised us. We are elect exiles. We always were. We only forgot it for as long as the culture let us.

Stanley Hauerwas and William Willimon wrote a book a generation ago and called it Resident Aliens, and the title was the whole argument. The church, they said, is a colony, an

outpost of one country planted in the soil of another, and its first job is not to run the host country but to be a faithful colony, visibly belonging to its true home. I think that is exactly right, and I think the reason it landed like cold water in 1989 is the reason it is daily bread now. We are finding out, the hard way and the only way, that we were never meant to own the country we live in. We were meant to be a colony of heaven inside it, and a colony that thinks it owns the territory has forgotten the only thing that made it a colony in the first place. The exile is not the end of us. It is the rediscovery of us. We are going home to who we are.

Chapter Eight: Depth Over Dominance

Everything until now has been diagnosis, and diagnosis is the easy part. Now I owe you the harder thing, which is what we actually do, and I am going to spend the rest of this book on it, and I am going to start with the sentence that the whole platform I write from is built on. The future of the American church does not belong to stronger tribes. It belongs to deeper disciples. And those are not two versions of the same project. They pull in opposite directions, and in the years ahead you are going to have to choose which one you are building.

Understand why depth was optional in Christendom and is not optional now. When the culture is carrying you, you can be a mile wide and an inch deep and survive just fine, because the water holds you up no matter how shallow your roots. A nominal faith, a Sunday faith, a faith of vague assent and cultural habit, works perfectly well in a world that assumes it. It only fails when the assumption fails. Jesus told a parable about exactly this and we have been mishearing it for generations. The seed that fell on rocky ground sprang up fast and green and looked the healthiest of all, until the sun came up, and because it had no root it withered in a morning. The sun is not the enemy in that parable. The sun is just the weather. The shallowness was the problem all along, and the sun only revealed it. Well, the sun has come up on the American church. The drought is here. And the only thing that lives through a drought is depth.

There was a philosopher named Alasdair MacIntyre who ended a

famous book in 1981 with an image the church has been chewing on ever since. He had spent the whole book arguing that the moral fabric of the West had unraveled past the point of repair, and at the end he turned to what faithful people should do in the ruins, and he reached back to the last time the West fell apart. In the collapse of the Roman order, he wrote, what saved the moral and spiritual life of Europe was not the people who tried to prop up the dying empire. It was the people who quietly built new communities where the life of virtue could be sustained through the long darkness. He said we are waiting for another, doubtless very different, Saint Benedict. He meant we need to stop trying to hold the empire up and start building the kind of deep communities that can carry the faith through a long winter, the way the monasteries carried it through the last one.

This is why formation has to replace mere reach as the strategy of the church. In Christendom the goal was reach, because belief was assumed and you just needed to get people in the building the culture had already half-filled for you. After Christendom, reach without depth is worse than useless, because you are gathering people into a shallow faith the secular age will evaporate by Thursday. James K.A. Smith has spent a career reminding us that we are not brains on legs who believe our way into the kingdom. We are creatures of love and habit, formed by what we do over and over, by liturgies, and the secular age has liturgies of its own, the scroll and the screen and the store, that are catechizing us all day long whether we notice or not. The church that survives the drought will be the church that forms people deeply enough to stand against that current, with practices and disciplines and a catechesis that goes down to the root. Not a bigger crowd. A deeper people.

The drought does not create shallow faith. It exposes

it. And the only answer to a drought has ever been roots that were put down long before the sky turned to brass.

I have to implicate myself here, because this is the sin I know from the inside. I came up in the era of platform and metrics and reach, and I wanted all of it, and I told myself the wanting was zeal for the kingdom. I have written about the loneliness that hides under the platform elsewhere, and I will not repeat it, but I will say this. The dominance model and the depth model finally come apart over a single question, which is whether you are willing to be small. Dominance cannot stand to be small. Depth does not mind. The Benedict that MacIntyre was waiting for was not waiting to be large. He was waiting to be faithful, in a community deep enough to outlast an empire, and the empire did fall, and the deep little communities did not, and that is not a coincidence. It is the pattern. It is the whole strategy of the long after, and it begins the day you stop trying to be wide and start letting God make you deep.

Chapter Nine: A Contrast Society

If the future belongs to deeper disciples and not to stronger tribes, then the next question is what a community of deep disciples is actually for, and the answer the New Testament gives is not the answer the American church usually gives. We tend to think the church exists to deliver religious goods and services to individuals, a place you go to get your spiritual needs met, a vendor of meaning. The New Testament thinks the church is itself the point. The community is not the delivery mechanism for the message. The community is the message. A scholar named Gerhard Lohfink had a phrase for what the church is meant to be, and the phrase is worth keeping. A contrast society. A people whose common life is so unlike the world around them that it becomes, all by itself, the argument.

Jesus said it more simply on the last night of His life. By this, He said, all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another. Not if you win the argument. Not if you take the culture. Not if you out-shout the other tribe. If you love one another, in a way the world can see and cannot reproduce, the world will know. The witness He staked everything on was not a position paper. It was a visible quality of life together, a love so concrete and so durable that an outsider could look at it the way that pagan looked at the Christians nursing his plague and ask the only question that matters, where does that come from, I want to know the God who makes people live like that.

And He told us what the contrast would be made of. The whole Sermon on the Mount is the constitution of a contrast society, a description of a community that runs on a completely different

physics than the world. A people who do not retaliate in an age of retaliation. A people who tell the truth when a lie would help. A people who keep their marriages when the culture treats vows as provisional. A people who forgive, who refuse to despise their enemies, who hold their money with an open hand in a civilization organized around the closed fist. None of that is natural. All of it is visible. A community that actually lived the Sermon on the Mount would not need a marketing department. It would need a bigger parking lot, because the exhausted and the cynical of a brutal age would come just to see if it was real.

Now hear the indictment, because it is ours. The reason the contrast is so faint right now is that the American church has mostly let the culture sort it into tribes exactly like all the other tribes. We have churches sorted by politics, where everyone votes the same and the gospel has quietly become the chaplaincy of a party. We have churches sorted by class and by race and by age and by taste, each one a comfortable affinity group of people who were already alike, which is the opposite of a contrast society, because there is no contrast in a room full of people the market would have gathered anyway. The world can produce an affinity group in its sleep. Only the gospel can produce a room where the slave and the master, the progressive and the conservative, the rich and the poor sit at one table and call each other family and mean it. That room is a miracle. The affinity group is just demographics with a steeple.

The world can assemble people who are already alike. Only the gospel can assemble people who have nothing in common but Christ, and that room, when it exists, is the most persuasive thing on earth.

So the work is not first to change the country. The work is first to

be the contrast, to let the church become again a society so visibly different that it cannot be explained by anything but the resurrection. This is slower than politics and quieter than a campaign and it does not photograph well, and it is the only thing that has ever actually worked. The early church did not lobby the empire into the kingdom. It out-loved it, in plain view, in thick communities of people the empire could not account for, until the watching world wore down and asked to come in. A thin church spread across a culture changes nothing. A thick church, deep and strange and visibly bound together by a love the age cannot manufacture, changes everything, and it changes it the way leaven changes bread, from the inside, slowly, and all the way through.

Chapter Ten: Witness, Not Conquest

We come now to the hardest habit the church has to break, and it is the habit of reaching for the lever. Christendom trained us, over sixteen centuries, to change the world by holding the controls, to assume that the way you accomplish a Christian end is to get Christian hands on the law and the throne and the institutions and pull. That instinct is so deep in us we mistake it for faithfulness. And it is the very instinct the church did not have, and could not have had, in the era when it actually turned the world upside down. The early church changed everything and it never once held a lever. It had only one tool, and the New Testament has a word for the tool, and the word is witness.

The Greek word is *martyria*, and you can hear our word martyr inside it, which tells you what kind of tool it is. Witness is what you do when you cannot coerce. You cannot make the watching world believe, you cannot legislate the kingdom into a heart, you cannot conquer your way to a conversion, so you do the only thing left, you live the truth out loud and in public and let it cost you what it costs, and you trust God with the result. Witness is the weapon of the powerless, and it is the only weapon Jesus ever actually authorized, and it is, by an enormous margin, the most effective weapon in the history of the world, because it converted Rome from the bottom of a prison.

Here is the irony the church has never fully faced. The day we got the lever, we started to lose the witness. When Constantine handed the church the empire, it looked like the greatest victory imaginable, and in many ways it brought real goods, but it also began a long slow trade that thinkers from John Howard Yoder to

Stanley Hauerwas have called the Constantinian shift. The church that could now command obedience slowly forgot how to compel by love. Why out-die an empire that is now yours to run. Why win the slow way, by witness, when you can win the fast way, by decree. And so the muscle of witness, the one that had carried the church for three centuries, began to atrophy the moment the lever was in reach, and it has been weak ever since, because a church with its hand on the controls never has to develop it.

Lesslie Newbigin, having watched the church lose its hold on the West, asked the essential question. How is it possible that the gospel should be credible, that people should come to believe that the power which has the last word in human affairs is represented by a man hanging on a cross. And he gave an answer that should be framed in every church that is afraid of the future. I am suggesting, he wrote, that the only answer, the only hermeneutic of the gospel, is a congregation of men and women who believe it and live by it. The only way the world will ever read the gospel is in the life of a community that embodies it. Not the billboard. Not the law. Not the election. The congregation, living the thing, in front of the neighbors, is the argument. There is no other translation of the gospel the world can actually read.

Witness is the weapon of a church that cannot coerce, which is to say it is the church's true weapon, because the church was never supposed to be able to coerce in the first place.

So I want to say to the part of us that is grieving the lost lever, and it is a large part, and it is in me too. The taking of the lever from our hands is a loss, and it is also the most freeing thing that

could happen to us, because the lever was a counterfeit, and it was quietly killing the only power we ever really had. A church that cannot coerce must persuade. A church that cannot legislate must love. A church that cannot conquer must witness, and bleed if it comes to that, and trust God with an outcome it can no longer manufacture. Look at what moral witness without the lever did in our own century through a Baptist preacher who never held an office and changed a nation from a jail cell with nothing but the truth and a willingness to suffer for it. That is the cruciform pattern, power made perfect in weakness, and it is the only pattern the cross ever endorsed. We are being handed back our crucified strength. We should take it like the gift it is.

Chapter Eleven: The Imagination We Lost

There is a kind of poverty that comes from traveling light for too long, and the American church is suffering from it badly. For centuries the culture carried the Christian memory for us, the calendar and the stories and the assumed furniture of a Christian imagination, so we did not have to carry it ourselves, and like anyone who lets someone else hold the heavy things we forgot how heavy they were and eventually forgot we owned them. Now the culture has set the bags down, and we have reached for our inheritance, and discovered that we are spiritually impoverished, holding a faith stripped down to a few slogans and a worship set, with two thousand years of depth sitting in a storehouse we forgot how to enter. The recovery of that storehouse is one of the central tasks of the long after.

Charles Taylor describes the modern self with a word that explains more about your own restlessness than you might expect. We have become, he says, buffered selves, sealed off, where our ancestors were porous selves, open to a world charged with God and meaning and spirit at every point. The modern condition is to live inside what he calls the immanent frame, a world experienced as closed, flattened, disenchanted, a universe of matter and mechanism with the transcendent pushed out to the far edges or out of the picture altogether. James K.A. Smith, reading Taylor for the rest of us, points out that this is the air we all breathe now, believer and unbeliever alike. Even our faith has gone thin and buffered. We believe in God the way you believe a fact, in our heads, in a flattened world, instead of dwelling in

Him the way the saints did, in a world lit up with His presence from the inside. The imagination we lost is the imagination of a full world, and you cannot argue your way back into it. You have to be re-formed into it.

The practices are how that re-formation happens, and they are exactly what Christendom let us neglect. The church spent two thousand years developing a technology of the soul, a whole architecture of practice designed to take an ordinary person and slowly form them into someone who can see and inhabit the real world, the one with God in it. Fixed-hour prayer that bends your whole day around God instead of around the feed. The Christian calendar that walks you through the entire gospel every single year until it is in your bones. Fasting that teaches your body that it does not have to obey every appetite. Confession that drags sin into the light where it loses its power. Sabbath, real Sabbath, the practice of stopping that declares with your whole body that the world is held by God and not by you. The creeds, the saints, the long memory, the practice of lament. We treated all of it as optional decoration on a faith we thought was mainly about believing the right things. It was never decoration. It was the formation. It was how you grow a porous soul in a buffered age.

This is why the way forward runs backward, into the Great Tradition, into the company of the dead. C. S. Lewis warned about what he called chronological snobbery, the unexamined assumption that whatever is newer is wiser and that the past has nothing to teach the present but its mistakes. Chesterton called the cure the democracy of the dead, tradition as the simple refusal to let the small and arrogant aristocracy of those who merely happen to be walking around right now outvote the vast company of those who came before. After Christendom, the church cannot afford chronological snobbery for one more day.

We are too thin, too new, too formed by the very age we are trying to resist, to draw only on our own shallow resources. We have to go back and drink from the deep wells, Augustine and the desert fathers and the medieval mystics and the Reformers and the long line of the faithful, not out of nostalgia, but because they were not buffered, and we are, and they have something we desperately need.

Christendom let us travel light, and we lost almost everything we were carrying. The recovery is not nostalgia. It is a thirsty people finally walking back to a well that never ran dry.

None of this is antiquarianism and none of it is escape. It is the opposite. A person formed by these old practices is not less able to face the post-Christian world, but vastly more, because they are no longer a thin modern self trying to believe a few facts against the whole weight of a disenchanted age. They are a deep and rooted creature who actually lives in the real world, the enchanted one, the one the secular age has trained everyone else to disbelieve. That is the imagination we lost, and it is the imagination the world is quietly starving for, whether it has words for the hunger or not. The buffered self is exhausted and does not know why. The church has the answer in its own storehouse, and the long work of the after is, in large part, the work of going back in and bringing it out.

Chapter Twelve: A People for the Long After

I want to end by telling you the truth about the timeline, because almost everything that goes wrong in the church right now goes wrong because we are in a hurry, and the people of God were never meant to be in a hurry. Here is the truth. You and I are not going to see the end of this. The recovery of a deep, faithful, post-Christendom church is not a project we will complete. It is not a problem we will solve in a program cycle or a campaign or a lifetime. We are early in something long. We are the early exiles, planting gardens whose fruit will feed people we will never meet, and if we cannot make our peace with that, we will keep reaching for the fast and ruinous answers, because the fast answers are really just the answers of people who cannot bear to wait.

Go back to Jeremiah's letter one last time, to the number the false prophet could not stand to say. Seventy years. Plant gardens, God told the exiles, because you are going to be here long enough to eat the fruit, and your children after you, and most of you are going to die in Babylon with the promise unfulfilled in your hands. That is not pessimism. It is the shape of faithfulness across generations. The whole impulse to take it back by force is, underneath the anger, a failure to accept the seventy years. It is the demand to see the harvest in our own lifetime, to be the generation that wins, and that demand has never produced anything but false prophets and broken people. The faithful plant gardens they will not harvest. The monks who copied the Scriptures by candlelight through the long centuries after Rome

fell did not live to see the civilization their faithfulness would seed. They just kept copying, in the dark, because it was true and because it was theirs to do.

And so I am not going to end this book by promising you that the church in America is about to turn it all around, because I do not know that, and neither does anyone selling it to you. What I know is older and steadier than a forecast. I know that the gates of hell will not prevail against the church, and I would ask you to notice who Jesus made that promise to. Not to an empire. Not to a majority. He made it to a dozen confused men standing in a pagan district under the shadow of a rock face carved full of the shrines of other gods, a tiny powerless band with no buildings and no budget and no cultural standing of any kind, and He told that little group that the gates of hell would not hold against them. The promise was never attached to our dominance. It was attached to Him, and to the strange deathless thing He started, and that thing has now outlived every single empire that ever presided over its funeral, and it will outlive this one too.

So be the church. That is the whole charge, and it is enormous. Be the contrast society in a culture of lonely tribes. Be the deep disciples in the age of the inch-deep. Be the witnesses who have set down the lever and picked up the cross. Be the elect exiles who seek the welfare of the city without bowing to its gods. Plant the gardens. Recover the old wells. Form your children deep enough to stand in the drought. Love one another so visibly that the exhausted world cannot account for it and finally comes to ask you why. None of that requires the water to come back. All of it is available to a church with no power at all, which is the only kind of church that has ever actually changed anything.

The promise was never made to an empire. It was

made to a powerless few, and it has outlived every empire since. We do not need Christendom back. We need only to be the church, which is the one thing we were always for.

I told you at the beginning that I came to Christ in the open sea, with no water under me and no culture holding me up, and that He was enough. I want to leave you there, because it is the truest thing I know about the country we are entering. The faith does not need the scaffolding. It never did. The men and women who will carry the church through the long after are not going to be the ones who spent their strength trying to nail the scaffolding back up, and they are not going to be the ones who let the building be torn down to please the age. They are going to be the ones who walked into the empty room where cultural Christianity used to stand, and found the Lord still there, exactly as the first disciples found Him, with no power and no majority and nothing to offer but Himself, and discovered all over again what the church keeps having to learn and keeps being given the grace to learn. He was always the only thing holding us up. The water was never the point. He was. He is. He will be, long after the last of the scaffolding has come down, and the building, His building, is still standing in the morning light.